

Cartographic Confluences: The Macuilxochitl Map as a Lens into Colonial and Indigenous Interactions

The map of Macuilxochitl is part of a broader iconographic corpus of local knowledge produced in response to official questionnaires used to compile the Geographical Accounts of the Indies. This corpus, comprising 74 maps archived in Seville, Madrid, and Austin, Texas, was drawn by various illustrators, each bringing their unique interpretations. This process, combined with cultural misunderstandings, altered the project's trajectory. As noted by Barbara Mundy, the indigenous people familiar with pictograms, glyphs, and logograms, used these visual recording methods in their narration, contrasting with the European reliance on written words.

In this attempt at unveiling the complexities and the significance of this historical artefact, I will go over major aspects of post-invasion dynamics and, through Juan Pimentel's secondary source, trace them back to our central focus. This way, while building a historical approach narrative throughout the paper, the reader will gain insight not only on less known aspects of the Abya Yala invasion consequences, but also get a grasp at indigenous self-realization and acute awareness of their new position at the time.

Juan Pimentel's notes further enrich our understanding of the map's significance. He references Fernandez de Oviedo's "Historia general y natural de las Indias" (1526-1557), which underscores the inadequacy of words to describe the natural wonders of the newly discovered lands, suggesting

that painters were better suited for this task. The map of Macuilxochitl, with its floating churches, ox and horse heading upriver, and three seated human figures in conversation, is not a Renaissance painting nor a modern map. It is a unique blend of historical events and cultural symbolism, reflecting a different epistemological approach. In order to explore those themes, I will first discuss indigenous labor in colonial exploitation systems, and then present environmental and agricultural transformations brought by colonization.

First of all, the transformation of labor and social structures in early colonial Abya Yala creates stratified realities. The post invasion context in Abya Yala brought about a number of changes from the violent settlement period. A new reality where European and indigenous populations co-existed in intensely stratified relations shaped a new era for the continent. This relation was ruled by labor for the most part: different versions of colonialism led to implementation of projects determining a range of ostracization of local populations. Indeed, extractivist colonialism focused on extracting precious metals and raw materials which for them included humans and saw labor as a tool to get resources, therefore perpetrating indigenous slavery until depletion of resources or lack of labor with the death of workers.

Following the initial phase of conquest, the *encomienda* system was institutionalized, granting successful invaders the right to own people as long as they converted them to Christianity. Bartolomé de las Casas, a former *encomendero* who later advocated for the abolition of the system, negotiated against other Spanish intellectuals. Despite his efforts, the resistance was mainly indigenous, with notable instances of uprisings and the establishment of *quilombos*.

The map illustrates this period of upheaval and resistance through its depiction of interconnected spaces of villages and trade networks. These elements highlight the continuity of pre-invasion connections and relations between indigenous groups, even under the oppressive encomienda system. The appearance of churches built on top of indigenous settlements on the map further signifies the imposition of European cultural elements and the forced conversion efforts.

The repartimiento system, introduced in 1550, sought to replace the encomienda by distributing indigenous labor managed by royal officials. In the Andes, the Spanish revived the indigenous Mit'a system in 1605, instituting a rotation of indigenous laborers who could benefit from the colonial government after a set amount of work. However, this system remained exploitative, displacing communities and subjecting workers to harsh conditions. Nonetheless, taking its roots in the Inca public labor system, putting up a facade of using local heritage gave more legitimacy to the system.

The map of Macuilxochitl also represents this continued exploitation and adaptation of indigenous systems. The depiction of roads as trade networks on the map signifies the maintenance of pre-invasion connections and the continuity of relations between indigenous groups, even under the exploitative repartimiento system. The map of Macuilxochitl serves as a powerful reminder of the enduring legacy of colonialism and the importance of preserving and honoring indigenous knowledge systems. The fragile balance at play here is overlooked by Juan Pimentel: he sees the presence of widely different cultural elements as a form of mixing and new start for both indigenous and colonial populations, but fails to remember traditions and heritage hold power, not necessarily compatible with one another and sometimes leading to the protection of one's own by the destruction of another's as seen with religiously justified eradication of local spiritual practices.

Secondly, colonial disruptions through European species and practices made a lasting impact on indigenous ecologies. If changes in the post invasion context of Abya Yala manifested in the relationship between races and cultures, they also physically shaped the geographical landscape, fauna and flora composition of the continent. As Europeans brought with them diseases, animals, and traditions from the old continent, these spread and caused much harm throughout communities. The effect of new diseases indigenous tribes had no immunity to is well known as the leading cause of death among Incas and other Empires: reportedly more than 90% of Amerindian indigenous population were decimated by smallpox, malaria and the bubonic plague in a matter of years. Less reported is the impact of imported animals on the continent: with no natural predators, animals let loose in the new environment disrupted the ecological cycle and chased indigenous populations away because of the lack of food. Mules for example were thought by conquistadores as the most practical means of goods transportation on the Inca trade network and 800 000 were brought from Europe but their hard feet severely damaged Inca roads. Pigs and goats were a source of devastation of crops and sheep also infested the continent.

The map of Macuilxochitl captures these ecological transformations through its detailed account of local plants and landscapes, alongside the depiction of imported animals such as cattle. This visual representation underscores the significant environmental and social changes brought about by the introduction of European species and agricultural methods.

The introduction of European preferred food sources clashed with indigenous agricultural practices, which were centered around the cultivation of the "three sisters" (corn, beans, and squash). These crops were not just a source of sustenance but also symbols of the natural resources and wealth that sustained indigenous life and were thoroughly cultivated throughout the region. The colonial disruption of these practices underscores the broader theme of ecological imperialism, where the imposition of foreign species and agricultural methods led to significant environmental and social changes.

The map's depiction of the central *altepetl*, or water mountain, symbolizes the indigenous cosmology and the god Macuilxochitl, associated with games, music, flowers, fertility, sacrifice, and regeneration. This central symbol, along with the bush with five flowers (*macuilli xochitl*), highlights the indigenous knowledge systems and their intimate relationship with the environment, disrupted by colonial practices. The writings in the Latin alphabet on the map also indicate the imposition of European cultural elements, yet the map remains deeply rooted in indigenous cosmology, reflecting a different epistemological approach.

Pimentel notes the map's circular realism, as highlighted by Alessandra Russo, which differs markedly from European cartographic conventions. This circular realism eschews Euclidean geometry and perspective in favor of a more holistic representation, which helps us understand the indigenous cosmology and the central *altepetl* symbol on the map. This approach highlights the resilience and agency of indigenous communities against the enduring legacy of colonialism.

In conclusion, the map of Macuilxochitl serves as a profound testament to the complex interplay between indigenous and European cultures in the post-invasion context of Abya Yala. Through its intricate depictions of interconnected spaces, ecological transformations, and cultural symbols, the map encapsulates the multifaceted consequences of colonialism. The encomienda and repartimiento systems, as illustrated in the map, highlight the exploitation and adaptation of indigenous systems, while the depiction of imported animals and altered landscapes underscores the profound environmental changes brought about by European colonization. The map's unique blend of historical events and cultural symbolism, as analyzed through Juan Pimentel's notes and Fernandez de Oviedo's observations, reveals a different epistemological approach that contrasts sharply with European cartographic conventions. Tracing these historical dynamics has highlighted the enduring legacy of colonialism and the importance of preserving and honoring indigenous knowledge systems. The map stands as a powerful reminder of the fragile balance between cultural elements and the often-destructive impact of colonial impositions. It also underscores the acute awareness and self-realization of indigenous communities as they navigated their new position in a rapidly changing world.

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